

FREE SAMPLE

Russian Tortoise Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 51-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 51 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 46 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/russian-tortoise/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free Russian tortoise care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/russian-tortoise/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Lengths appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm), millimeters (mm) or meters (m) beside them, and floor area in square feet (sq ft). A tortoise and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows, with pounds (lb) for scale. Soaks are timed in minutes (min). Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a tortoise yet

Check the law first, on page 25: a Russian tortoise is legal in most of the United States, but one state bans it and five want a permit. Then read pages 4 to 12 in order before buying anything. The enclosure and the UVB fixture are the two decisions people get wrong most, and both are expensive to redo. Buy once, from the Budget & Shopping List on page 36.

If your tortoise is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist on page 34. Do two checks today: the basking spot's surface temperature, read with the infrared temperature gun, and the UVB tube's age, since its output fades long before the light looks dim. If the animal itself seems off, go to page 27.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 34: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 42: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 35: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 43: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 39: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 44: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 40: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 15: the never-feed list, for the fridge |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The Russian tortoise is hardy, which is why poor care can run for years before it shows. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary and specialist sources on page 48.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile veterinarian with tortoise experience. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law pages is legal advice either.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Testudo horsfieldii</i> , also sold as Horsfield's tortoise
Native range	Central Asia: Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Iran, Afghanistan, Pakistan and western China. Semi-arid steppe, rocky desert and dry scrub
Adult size	5 to 10 in (13 to 25 cm) of shell; females run slightly larger than males
Captive lifespan	40 years or more is typical, and some reach 50 plus
Diet type	Herbivore: grass hay and weeds, high in fiber and calcium, no fruit and no animal protein (page 13)
Indoor enclosure	An open-topped tortoise table. 4×2 ft (120×60 cm), about 8 sq ft, is the floor; 7×3.5 ft (210×105 cm), about 24.5 sq ft, is the adult working size
Temperatures	Basking surface about 95°F (35°C); cool end in the 70s°F (21 to 26°C); night no lower than 60°F (16°C)
UVB	A linear T5 HO tube (T5: a fluorescent tube five-eighths of an inch across; HO: high output), giving a UVI (ultraviolet index, the strength of the UVB) of 3.0 to 4.0 at the basking spot
Humidity	40 to 50% at the open surface for an adult, 40 to 75% for a juvenile, plus a moist hide
Brumation	A winter slowdown the species is built for, and optional indoors (page 24)
Social	Alone, or two females with care. Never two males
Conservation status	Vulnerable on the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) Red List, the global list of threatened species, and on Appendix II of CITES (the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species), so international trade runs on export quotas

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$50 to \$150 for a hatchling or young captive-bred tortoise, \$225 to \$400 for an older one. \$490 to \$935 for the full indoor setup, of which the table alone is \$125 to \$250. Every line is on page 36.

Yearly ongoing

\$370 to \$695 a year, about \$30 to \$60 a month, for food, supplement top-ups, substrate, two UVB tubes a year, electricity and a wellness exam with a fecal test (a stool check for parasites).

THE NUMBER THAT SHOULD DECIDE THIS

Forty years at \$370 to \$695 a year comes to \$14,800 to \$27,800, before a single illness, and illness with tests or medication commonly runs \$150 to \$300 or more each time. A tortoise bought today is very likely to need a second keeper. Plan who that is before you buy (page 41).

The species, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species, several names

The pet Russian tortoise is *Testudo horsfieldii*, also sold as Horsfield's tortoise. It is a compact, hardy animal of the arid steppe and rocky desert of Central Asia, and one of the most cold-tolerant tortoises in the world. In the clay and sand deserts of its range it is above ground for only about three months a year, roughly March through May. It digs tunnels up to 2 m (about 6.5 ft) long into hillsides or under stones, or takes over an old marmot or hedgehog burrow, and from late May it drops out of sight: some populations spend June to August underground in a summer dormancy, and all of them sit out the winter deep in the same burrow.

Even in the active season it feeds in two short windows a day, mid-morning and late afternoon, and over a season wild tortoises eat more than 80 plant species from 27 families. That is the animal this package is built around: a burrow to disappear into, a daily round between shelter and forage, and a diet that changes constantly.

Size and growth

Adult length	5 to 10 in (13 to 25 cm) of shell. The largest verified animals reach about 22 cm (close to 9 in) of straight shell length.
Hatchling	About 42 to 50 mm (1.7 to 2 in) of shell and 18 to 23 g out of the egg
Growth	Slow, over years. Fast growth is a warning rather than an achievement (page 17)
Males and females	Males have a much longer tail, usually tucked to one side; females are slightly larger. Sexual maturity comes at around 10 years

Lifespan

40 years or more is typical in captivity, and some individuals reach 50 plus. Wild lifespan is not well documented; the widely quoted 40 to 50 years is a captive-care figure. A Russian tortoise stays small enough at 5 to 10 in to spend that whole life indoors on a tortoise table, which is its real advantage over the larger tortoises. It is also why rehoming is common: the animal routinely outlives the plans made for it.

WILD-CAUGHT, CAPTIVE-BRED, AND THE DIFFERENCE TO YOU

The species has been traded heavily for the pet market since the mid-1970s, and for most of that history a wild-caught animal was the norm. Uzbekistan is the main exporter today, Ukraine supplies a smaller share, and captive breeding runs alongside a continuing wild-caught supply. Wild-caught tortoises arrive stressed and carrying parasites, and die at a higher rate than captive-bred ones. Captive-bred costs more and is the better choice. What to look for in the animal itself is on page 21.